

DREAMING AGES HISTORY · EPISODE 9

Ancient Rome at Night

One Night in Trajan's Rome, 113 CE

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A BEDTIME COMPANION

A map of Rome and its water, the named hours of a Roman night, the real places and people behind the story, and a short list of trusted books and places to visit, for the evenings when you would like to wander a little further.

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Rome and its countryside

Let's begin by finding our way to the city.



Rome and a lake northwest of the city plotted at their real locations on a modern map (Natural Earth). Springs in the hills around the lake fed Trajan's new aqueduct, the Aqua Traiana, opened in 109 CE. Water ran to the city by gravity alone, with no pumps on the main run.

AT A GLANCE

- Early autumn in 113 CE, while the emperor Trajan rules
- About one million people, a conventional estimate
- Most of them in rented rooms above the shops
- Water arriving by gravity from springs far beyond the walls

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Places you'll visit in the episode

A short, slow tour of the real places behind the story.

The street fountain · Public basins had first call on the water, ahead of the baths and private pipes, and ran all night.

The insulae · Rented apartment blocks with shops below; Trajan capped their height at 60 Roman feet, about 17.75 metres.

The Subura · The crowded valley of tall tenements, shut off from the forums by a massive wall.

Insula dell'Ara Coeli · The only apartment block that survives in Rome: five storeys at the foot of the Capitoline.

The Aqua Traiana · Trajan's aqueduct, inaugurated in 109 CE, fed by springs in the hills around a lake northwest of Rome.

The Baths of Trajan · Dedicated in June 109; their cistern, the Seven Halls, held up to eight million litres.

A lamp shop · Clay oil lamps holding about 20 millilitres of fuel, many from factories in northern Italy and southern Gaul.

A cook-shop counter · The thermopolium, with jars set into masonry, and the popina, a wine bar serving olives, bread and stew.

A bakery yard · Where the pistores grind and bake through the dark so bread is ready at dawn.

Trajan's Forum · Inaugurated in 112, paved in Carrara marble, with the Basilica Ulpia and Trajan's Column.

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A Roman night, hour by hour

Here is the Roman night, one named hour at a time.

THE NIGHT AT A GLANCE

Vespera	Concubia nox	Media nox	Dawn
The first star	Bedtime	The day turns	The salutatio

The Romans gave the night a row of names. The few ordinary people in the episode are imagined; the city, its laws and its writers are real. Times are approximate.

Vespera — Evening, after sunset. The first star comes out over the roofs.

Crepusculum — Twilight. The last pale light thins over the roofs.

Prima fax — The first torch: the oil lamps are lit.

Supper — Stew, olives and wine at a counter; many rented rooms had no kitchen.

Concubia nox — Bedtime. Water is carried upstairs, and the house grows still.

Night carts — Kept out by day, heavy carts roll in with grain and timber.

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Through the night to morning

The city sleeps, and the watch and the bakers keep working.



Intempesta nox — The dead of night. The vigiles walk their rounds with buckets.

Media nox — Midnight. The Roman civil day turns.

Gallicinium — Cock-crow. The bakers' mills have turned for hours.

Conticinium — The hush after cock-crow, before dawn.

Dawn — Clients gather at a patron's door for the salutatio.

Morning — The company walks to Trajan's Forum in the first sun.

A Roman night hour was one twelfth of the dark: about 75 minutes at midwinter and about 45 at midsummer. Water clocks, set from a sundial, kept the count after sunset.

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THE WIDER WORLD

Trajan's Rome and its world

Now let's step back and see the wider world that fed the city.



Approximate extent of the Roman Empire around 100 CE, simplified from the open historical-basemaps dataset.

FROM FAR AND NEAR

- Trajan's Forum was paid for with spoils from Dacia
- Factory lamps came from northern Italy and southern Gaul
- Trajan's architect was a man from Damascus

People you'll meet

The real names, and a few imagined ones, that you'll hear along the way.

Trajan · Emperor on this night in 113 CE; his forum, column, aqueduct and baths are all new.

Augustus · Reorganised the night watch in 6 CE and capped apartment blocks at 70 Roman feet.

Frontinus · Curator of the aqueducts from 97 CE; around 100 he described nine of them.

Trajan's architect · A man from Damascus who oversaw the building of Trajan's Forum.

Quintus Rammius Martialis · Prefect of the vigiles, known from at least 111 to 113.

Juvenal · Satirist whose speaker asks who but the wealthy can sleep in Rome.

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People you'll meet

Martial · Poet who complained of corn grinders working at night.

Marcus Vergilius · Baker of the late Republic whose tomb, about seven metres high, still stands.

Cicero · Held a one-eighth share of an apartment block, and thought baking humble work.

Julia, Felix & Secunda · Imagined: a food-counter keeper, her upstairs neighbour, and a woman carrying water.

Daphne, Prima & Sabinus · Imagined: a lamp seller, a cloak mender and a porter at supper.

Vibius, Decimus & Clemens · Imagined: a carter, a watchman and a client, with Tertius the clerk, Hilarus the timekeeper, and the bakers Titus and Lucius.

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WHILE YOU LISTEN

Things to spot, and what is real

A few small things to listen for, and a note on what is found and what is imagined.

THINGS TO SPOT IN THE EPISODE

- The ring handle and leaf-shaped thumb rest on a clay oil lamp
- Rope buckets sealed with pitch, carried by the little bucket fellows
- Wet patchwork quilts, called centones, for smothering a fire
- The clerk's stroke in the wax as the civil day turns at midnight
- Trajan's Column, dedicated on 12 May 113, rising between two libraries

WHAT WE KNOW, AND WHAT WE IMAGINE

The city, its laws, buildings and writers are real, and the dates come from the record. The named ordinary people are imagined, though people very like them lived in these streets. The figure of a million people is an estimate, not a census, and Juvenal and Martial wrote sharp satire, not calm reports.





Artistic impressions of a clay oil lamp beside a loaf, and of Trajan's Column between its two libraries, made for the episode. They are not historical records.

FOR ANOTHER QUIET EVENING

Books to read

If you'd like to wander a little further, here are some trusted places to start.

Daily Life in Ancient Rome ↗, Jérôme Carcopino, ed. Henry T. Rowell, trans. E. O. Lorimer (Yale University Press).

A Day in the Life of Ancient Rome ↗, Alberto Angela, trans. Gregory Conti (Europa Editions, 2009).

The Sixteen Satires ↗, Juvenal, trans. Peter Green (3rd edition, Penguin Classics, 1998).

The Stratagems and the Aqueducts of Rome ↗, Frontinus, trans. Charles E. Bennett (Loeb Classical Library 174, Harvard University Press).

📚 FIND THESE BOOKS — TAP HERE →

Full reading list ↗



An artistic impression made for the episode, not a historical record.

FOR ANOTHER QUIET EVENING

Museums, places and one last thought

Museums & places

Trajan's Markets – Museum of the Imperial Forums: the Markets of Trajan, beside the remains of Trajan's Forum and the Column.

Insula dell'Ara Coeli: the one surviving Roman apartment block, at the foot of the Capitoline.

The Trevi Fountain: where the water of the Aqua Virgo still arrives today.

Pompeii Archaeological Park: the Thermopolium of Asellina and the town's bakeries.

A BEDTIME QUESTION

If you lived in Trajan's Rome, which room would you choose: a cheap one at the top of the stairs, or a dearer one just above the shop?

"The roofs are dark, the stars turn slowly over the seven hills, and the water keeps running, soft and steady, all through the night."

LISTEN TO THE FULL EPISODE ON YOUTUBE OR YOUTUBE MUSIC

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